

WELLNESS FOR THE HELPING PROFESSIONS



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Wellness for the Helping Professions

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Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Preface

Preface

The Creation of this Open Education Resource (OER)

In 2023, the Illinois State Legislature made available \$3 million in funding dedicated to Open Education Resource creation. This money was disbursed to academic institutions throughout the state via a 2-year competitive grant (2024-2026) that was overseen by the Illinois Secretary of State/Illinois State Library and facilitated by the [Consortium of Academic and Research Libraries in Illinois \(CARLI\)](#). This textbook and ancillary materials were part of Trinity Christian College's grant submission entitled *OER CARES: Cultivating Academic Resources to Equip Students*. From the grant, four separate projects were funded, including this one created for NURS 222: Wellness for the Helping Professions.

The grant's primary purpose is to develop Open Educational Resources (OER) throughout the state of Illinois to reduce textbook costs for students and encourage student success. Developed OER course materials will be released under a license that permits their free use, reuse, modification, and sharing with others.

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Contributors to the development of this OER textbook/ancillary material include educators, librarians, and staff from Trinity Christian College.

Illinois Secretary of State/Illinois State Library/CARLI Project Staff

The State of Illinois OER grant project would not have been possible without the support of the Illinois State Library and CARLI staff. Topical experts shared their knowledge on open educational resources, accessibility, author rights, instructional design, and publishing.

- Alexi Giannoulas, Illinois Secretary of State
- Greg McCormick, Illinois State Library Director
- Anne Craig, CARLI Senior Director
- Michele Leigh, Project Director, CARLI Senior Coordinator for Open Illinois
- Elizabeth Clarage, CARLI Director of Collections Services and OER Committee Liaison
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TBD

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For the Instructor



Thank you for considering the use of some or all of this text in your course. We feel very strongly and passionately that all people, but particularly those people in the helping professions, need to care for themselves in order to be fully present to care for others. We hope that you will find this text to provide some helpful guidance and tools to meet those primary objectives.

This text was created to accompany a 1-credit, 15-week, semester-long course. As such, each module (or chapter) is intended to take roughly one week of the course. However, as the text continues to expand, more than 15 activities (and therefore modules) may be included. All this means is that it is up to the course instructor to pick and choose both the wellness activities they want to feature and the order that they occur. Even we, the authors, jump around to different chapters from time to time! It helps to keep the students on their toes if they do not know which chapter they will be working with that week.

In our 1-hour class, students start by completing the reflection from the chapter that was covered during the past week. Sometimes there is a brief discussion in class allowing students the opportunity to share about anything they learned or noted about the previous activity. Then we transition to the new chapter, giving the students about 5-10 minutes to read and engage with the text. The class then actively engages with the new activity for the remainder of the class session, ending with a brief review of the Weekly Recommendations/Homework for that week (i.e., how to engage in the activity for at least 1 hour outside of class). This has worked for us, but feel free to modify it to meet your individual or group objectives.

A teaching strategy that we have had success with is utilizing guests to our classroom. Whenever possible, we invite guest lecturers/leaders to explain and participate in that week's activity. For example, having a passionate professor who teaches about children's literature and has a blog full of book recommendations is a great way to introduce the chapter [Reading for Fun](#). Having a certified yoga instructor lead the chapter on [Yoga](#) (or even Yoga and [Breathwork](#) together) is another great option. Use the expertise around you whenever possible.

In many of the chapters, we note that there is limited research on the (hopefully positive!) effects of a particular wellness activity specific to the helping professions. There is a massive opportunity for scholarship specific to the wellness needs of those in the helping professions, like healthcare workers. Perhaps this text will encourage further exploration of evidenced-based practices and research to expand our current knowledge of wellness for these areas of need. Research for this population would be great!

We have tried to be consistent with the language of the text. At times, the text will refer to the 'course' (i.e., thinking of the entirety of the text in an academic setting) while at other times we will refer to the 'text' in general since most of the modules/chapters can be utilized à la carte outside of a full course.

Anything about Christian integration? Feel free to delete if not necessary... Because the authors of this text work at a Christian higher education institution, Biblical integration is part of our course design. For this text, though, we have limited much of that language to a single paragraph in the background section. Regardless of your belief system, we hope that you will be open to the integration of spiritual practices as a core component of wellness and consider their importance in living a healthy and balanced life.

However you choose to use the information, we hope that it will be meaningful, intentional, and help to care for yourself and others.

~ Tina and Emily (the authors)

1: Introduction

Welcome to Wellness for Helping Professions!

We are glad you are here! This text is designed to be a starting point for those who want to explore, understand, and improve their personal wellness, with a specific focus on those who work and care for others. The format of the course is centered around trying various self-care activities followed by reflection. Some of these activities may be ones you engage with regularly while others may allow you to step outside your comfort zone. As you engage with each of these self-care practices, it is our hope that you will learn to identify your own sources of stress, build healthier habits that help you thrive, and develop a toolbox of activities that can help ground you as you work with and care for others.



Figure 1.1: Self-care practices are essential to manage stress and keep you grounded as you work with others. (Photo by Jorge Urosa from Pexels.)

Course Goals

The course goals (learning outcomes) will be that the student will be able to:

1. **Assess** and **identify** their own wellness needs
2. **Identify** different approaches to meet different wellness needs
3. **Create** a plan for ongoing responsiveness to assess needs and implement practices for wellness
4. **Create** new habits related to wellness
5. **Demonstrate** an awareness of ethical, professional, and Christ-like behaviors related to self-care

Course Recommendations and Structure

There are some recommendations on how you can gain the most from this course:

- Be willing to commit to being an active participant in all activities, not just the 'comfortable' ones
- Set aside 1 hour each week at a consistent time to start a new module and work through and/or complete the activity
- Outside of the 1-hour class, set aside an additional minimum of 1 hour per week to practice the activity
- *Reflect* on your incorporation of that activity, the benefits and barriers to your wellness that week, and how that activity impacted your wellness
- Consider recruiting others to do this course with you. While this course is about working on your personal wellness, many of the activities are great to do with others. Participating with a partner or a group can also help with accountability to stick to your plan!
- **DO NOT** try only the activities that are comfortable or seem interesting. **DO** try activities that push boundaries and explore new ideas!

As an introductory, exploratory course utilizing evidence-based activities, you are encouraged to try new activities and explore your own wellness and wellness needs. This course is not intended to be a long-term wellness plan, but rather, it is meant to help you develop habits that can turn into a more permanent approach to wellness. When you are able to identify activities that meet

your wellness needs, we encourage you to dig deeper into those practices and expand beyond the introductory level explored in this course.

Why is this course important to the helping professions?

People who work in the helping professions are, by definition, helping others. They often have personalities that feed off of giving to others and providing care or education for those in need. However, while giving of themselves, helping professionals may not consider their own needs and are vulnerable to stress, frustration, anxiety, and fatigue. Thus, proper self-care is both a responsibility and a necessity in order to be at one's best (Radlauer-Doerfler & VanDenBerg, 2020).

To give some practical, evidence-based examples, here are several examples from research in various helping fields:

Nursing

In 2013, the American Nursing Association (ANA) launched its [HealthyNurse Health Risk Appraisal](#). From the findings of the report, nearly every indicator showed that the health of American nurses is worse than that of the average American. This includes data showing that American nurses are more likely to be overweight, have higher levels of stress, and get less than the recommended hours of sleep (American Nurses Association, n.d.). Further, hazards such as workplace violence and musculoskeletal injuries also contributed to poorer health.

Social Work

Numerous studies have shown evidence that social workers are at risk for higher levels of burnout and stress because of their jobs (Ratcliff, 2024; Schraer, 2015). Larger organizations like the [National Association of Social Workers \(NASW\)](#) have changed their code of ethics (2021) to encourage proactive self-care amongst social workers to improve professional excellence, thereby recognizing the importance of mentally healthy workers.

Teaching

Teachers constantly work with students on a daily basis and are at higher risk for burnout which is often manifested physically or psychologically (Nápoles, 2021). A systematic review showed that teacher burnout was associated with headaches, illness, and voice disorders, among other physical factors (Madigan et al., 2023). Psychologically, one study showed that the proportion of teachers reporting psychological distress was twice as high as compared to a general population sample (Biron et al., 2008).

Personal Training

Personal and athletic trainers are not immune from experiencing burnout, potentially due to irregular hours and long hours (Oglesby et al., 2020). Moreover, because of the nature of the job of a personal trainer in helping people transform their bodies, personal trainers may experience higher levels of dissatisfaction with their own body and would benefit from exercises in self-compassion (Ebbeck & Austin, 2018).

Regardless of the helping profession, there is clear research and evidence that both physical and psychological issues can manifest themselves due to the work being done. To be at our optimal selves, it is vitally important that we take care of ourselves first so that we can maximize our impact on others. Our hope is that not only will you recognize your need for intentional self-care, but that you will actively engage in self-care activities to live your best life.

Reflection

What brought you to explore this course?

What has you interested in exploring wellness?

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2: Getting Started - Assessments

Background

"You can't really know where you are going until you know where you have been"

- Maya Angelou

How do we start the exploration of wellness that is the purpose of this course? This first activity looks to set a path forward, by starting with an in-depth evaluation of where you are at now when it comes to wellness.

[Princeton U Matter \(n.d.\)](#) defines wellness as "not merely the absence of illness or distress, [but] a lifelong process of making decisions to live a more balanced and meaningful life" (para. 1). The first step in that process is evaluating your current state, which is similar to many models of improvement including the nursing process. The nursing process follows 5 systematic steps: assess, diagnose, plan, implement, and evaluate ([Toney-Butler & Thayer, 2023](#)). Many other helping professions have a similar approach to practice. For example, quality improvement (QI) is something frequently discussed in healthcare. While comparing oneself to healthcare may not be the most therapeutic way to start a course focused on promoting wellness, it can be helpful to borrow a few concepts from QI models. The Model for Improvement used by the [Institute for Healthcare Improvement \(n.d.\)](#) starts by asking three fundamental questions that can be adapted for students in this course.

Definition: The Model for Improvement

The **Model for Improvement** asks three fundamental questions:

1. What are we (am I) trying to accomplish?
2. How will we (I) know that a change is an improvement?
3. What changes can we (I) make that will result in improvement?

One way to answer these questions and complete the assessment stage of the nursing process is to use a variety of inventories or tools to gather data. These assessments can identify different wellness needs that will assist you in creating a plan to better your own wellness.



Figure 2.1: Start making changes now. (Photo by Markus Winkler from Pexels)

Activity

This week, you are going to complete a variety of assessments/inventories to gather data about your wellness needs and create individual goals for the course. Taking these assessments should help with the three questions posed in the Model for Improvement. In some ways, this week can be the hardest in the course because it asks participants to dig deeply into their experiences. This takes vulnerability, strength, and courage! Do not be discouraged if this week's activity feels heavy or difficult. Try to recognize that this marks a starting point or baseline for the adventure of this class. The goal is to help you gather data to better inform you of what your needs are and to help you evaluate how you are responding to the different activities each week!

You will complete five assessments this week:

1. Princeton U Matter
2. Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale
3. Hassles & Uplifts
4. Symptoms of Stress
5. Resting Heart Rate

Why are there so many different assessments? Each assessment measures different aspects of wellness which are discussed more in the following sections.

Materials Suggested

- Device with access to Internet (and possibly a printer) to access the assessments to be completed
- Writing utensil and paper or note app to document results
- Optional: SmartWatch for tracking heart rate
 - *Note:* You can either download and print the assessments or take them digitally. Regardless, you need to document your responses for each assessment (if appropriate) and your results to refer back to them throughout the rest of the class.



Figure 2.1: Use a laptop, paper, writing instrument, and a SmartWatch. (Photo by KATRIN BOLOVTSOVA from Pexels)

Directions

Please take the time needed to carefully fill out the following five assessments and record your results using this chart. This chart is also available as a PDF download: [Assessment Summary](#)

Assessment Summary

A table depicting each assessment with a place for scores and notes and comments.

Tool	Your Score	Notes or Comments
Princeton U Matter: Emotional		
Princeton U Matter: Environmental		
Princeton U Matter: Intellectual		
Princeton U Matter: Occupational		
Princeton U Matter: Physical		
Princeton U Matter: Social		
Princeton U Matter: Spiritual		
Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale		
Hassles & Uplifts: Hassles		

Hassles & Uplifts: Uplifts		
Symptoms of Stress		
Resting Heart Rate		

Princeton U Matter

The [Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment](#) prompts the user to consider their current state in 7 different dimensions including: emotional, environmental, intellectual, occupational, physical, social, and spiritual.

Take the assessment using one of the links below:

- [Electronic access to Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment](#) (recommended for ease of use of results)
- [Print version of Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment](#)

Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale

The Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS) is an updated assessment based off the 1967 Holmes and Rahe Life Stress Inventory. Its goal is to measure the impact of various life events and how susceptible you might be to a stress-induced health breakdown ([Wallace et al., 2023](#)). Similarly, the Students' Stress Rating Scale (SSRS) is a 35-item variation on the Holmes and Rahe assessment tailored to college students and stresses that they might be facing ([Balamurugan & Kumaran, 2008](#)). These assessments can be valuable in helping you identify significant events that have the possibility of affecting your wellness, as well as giving you an opportunity to think about modifiable vs non-modifiable stressors.

Pick one of the following to complete:

- [Electronic access to Social Readjustment Rating Scale](#) (recommended for ease of use of results)
- [Print version of Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Print version of Students' Stress Rating Scale Rating Scale](#) (no electronic version available)

Hassles & Uplifts

The Hassles and Uplifts Scales (HUS) was constructed as a tool to focus on relatively minor events that happen in everyday life. This was a response to, in large part, the significance in psychological testing that the Social Readjustment Rating Scale had taken in measuring major life events ([Kanner et al., 1981](#)). While large stressors can and will happen, it is often the daily interactions or choices that impact our mood and our stress levels.

Take the assessment using the link below:

[Print version of Hassles and Uplifts Scale](#)

Note: Please read the full directions for completing the assessment to ensure you are completing the assessment accurately. After assigning a score of 0-3 for each item, add the score up for all Hassles, and then add up the score for all Uplifts.

Symptoms of Stress Table

Stress can cause many physical symptoms, some of which may be more obvious than others. The Symptoms of Stress Table can be used to identify what stress is doing to the body. Results can prompt goal setting related to those symptoms ([Sairanen et al., 2024](#)). This assessment has elements of the Calgary Symptoms of Stress Inventory (C-SOSI; [Carlson & Thomas, 2007](#)), but it is important to note that this assessment is not as comprehensive as that validated tool. The C-SOSI is primarily used by researchers to analyze data on stress symptoms in specific populations, whereas this Symptoms of Stress table is intended as a self-assessment to help identify different ways stress may be showing up in your body.

Take the assessment (found on page 2) using the link below.

Symptoms of Stress Table

To quantify this table, add up the scores as follows for each answer: Almost all day, every day (6 pts.); Once or twice daily (5 pts.); Every night or day (4 pts.); 2-3 times per week (3 pts.); Once a week (2 pts.); Once a month (1 pt.); Never (0 pts.). Record your total score in the assessment summary table.

Resting Heart Rate

Your heart rate can be used as one indicator of health and provides a quantitative piece of data to track. Many things can impact your heart rate, such as fitness level, temperature, and body position. For this course, it is particularly helpful to note that your emotions can impact your heart rate ([American Heart Association, 2025](#)). Once you know what your resting heart rate tends to be, you can use that as a gauge to analyze if stress or emotions may be impacting you physically in any given moment.



On the Wrist

Figure 2.1: Find your pulse on your wrist. Take your heart rate for 60 seconds. (Photo by BruceBlas from Wikimedia Commons)

Recommendations for tracking your resting heart rate this week:

- Find a consistent time that you can check your heart rate each day. Ideally, this would be at the start of each day.
 - *Note:* If you wear a fitness tracking device, the device may do this for you.
- Take your heart rate. If you are not familiar with taking your heart rate or could use a refresher, here are some step-by-step instructions from the [Mayo Clinic \(2024\)](#).
- If you notice that you are feeling stressed or are experiencing heightened emotions, take a moment to check your heart rate and note any changes from your resting heart rate.

Assessment Summary

If you have not already done so, please record your assessment scores and any interesting observations or notes you had from taking these assessments: see the [Assessment Summary](#).

Assessing wellness and stress is a complex and challenging process. Today you assessed your wellness from many different perspectives. Look back over each of the assessment tools. You will see that these tools measured wellness and stress from a variety of perspectives including:

- Physiological indicators of stress
- Your perception of what is happening in your life
- Sources of stress and frequency of hassles
- Your level of satisfaction with events in your life
- Type of life events you have experienced

Key Points

- Testing, measuring, and understanding yourself (i.e., assessment) is the first important step in developing a plan for wellness and reduction of stress.
- Stress can trigger physiological changes like an increased pulse. Symptoms of stress can include headache, muscle tension, insomnia, and a host of other warning signs. Listen to what your body is telling you as you continue through this course.
- Perception is key when assessing stress. The same situation can elicit a very different stress response in different individuals due to the individual's perception of the experience. It is okay if you experience something differently than others around you! Be honest with yourself so you can be most responsive to your needs.
- For a balanced picture of wellness, consider all dimensions of wellness including emotional, environmental, intellectual, occupational, physical, social, and spiritual.
- No single assessment, survey, or tool can tell the whole picture when it comes to assessing your wellness. Consider the results from all of these assessments to gain a better understanding of your personal wellness needs.

? Weekly Recommendation/Homework 2.1

The real impact of this activity is in **what you will do with the information you learned** about yourself. In this course, you will have the opportunity to explore different evidenced-based practices to develop a plan that is responsive to your wellness needs.

This week, continue to reflect on what you learned from the assessments. Take 5-10 minutes each day to check in with yourself about what you are feeling. Are you experiencing different physical symptoms of stress? Be attentive in listening to your body and assessing your ongoing needs.

Think about the Hassles and Uplifts assessment. Are there things that you can turn into more of uplifts? Are there hassles you can avoid or minimize? Try to be more aware of these throughout your week and repeat the assessment at least one more time to see if your results change with being more intentional about how you view each item.

Before the week is done, it is time to make some goals! Share in your reflection.

Reflection

1. Think back to the three questions from the Models for Improvement (given below) that began this section. Reflect on them in light of your scores on the assessments.
 1. What am I trying to accomplish?
 2. How will I know that a change is an improvement?
 3. What changes can I make that will result in improvement?
2. In light of your reflection, what are 3-5 specific goals that you can work towards to improve your wellness?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [Weekly Recommendation/Homework - Chapter 2](#)

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3: Breathwork

Background

Three different scenarios: a women in labor, a friend laying hurt on a soccer field, and a student about to take a test. What do they all have in common? In each one of these situations, I locked eyes with someone else and decided that one of the best things that I could do was to shift the focus in the moment onto something that should happen without any thought: Breathing.

Take a deep breath is common saying used for when someone is upset, flustered, or struggling. Yet that simple phrase is backed by evidenced-based research. Breathing, something every human needs to do, has the power to directly affect stress and anxiety when specific practices are used ([Bentley et al., 2023](#)). Whether referred to as breathwork, breathing practices, therapeutic breathing, or a specific breathing pattern like box-breathing, the evidence supporting use of these practices is plentiful and varied. For example, daily 5-minute breathwork demonstrated improved mood, reduction in respiratory rate, and reduced anxiety ([Balban et al., 2023](#)). Evidence also supports the use of breathing techniques in almost all settings, including with students and healthcare providers. One study showed that performing 5 minutes of relaxing breathing improved medical resident performance in a high-fidelity simulation ([Schlatter et al., 2022](#)). A different review demonstrated that study participants who participated in controlled breathing patterns demonstrated increased heart rate variability, improved decision-making on tasks, and decreased perceived stress ([De Couck et al., 2019](#)).

Breathing practices have the additional advantage of being accessible to anyone and cost-free ([Bentley et al., 2023](#)). These practices can also be implemented in any setting with limited training, making it easy to scale their use ([Fincham et al., 2023](#)). As such, the application opportunities are nearly endless with benefits possible for college students, teachers, healthcare providers, and even patients. Everyone can benefit from focused breathing!

The benefits of breathwork can be explored even more deeply by thinking back to where the very first breath came from. Genesis 2:7 reads "Then the LORD God formed the man from the dust of the ground. He breathed the breath of life into the man's nostrils, and the man became a living person." Think about it: the very breath of life that every human uses is a gift that came straight from the LORD. This is reiterated in Job 33:4, which proclaims: "For the Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life." We are each so thoughtfully and wonderfully created. Is it no wonder that careful and deliberate use of the gift of breath can have wellness benefits?

Activity

This week is all about exploring a variety of controlled breathing patterns. For beginners, it is recommended to try these techniques in a quiet and comfortable setting, but they can be practiced anywhere. Once comfortable with these techniques, it can be beneficial to challenge oneself to implement them in more difficult settings or in times of more acute stress.

Materials Suggested

1. Chair, if doing techniques sitting down.
 2. Open mind that is prepared to try something new
-

Directions

With each approach that you will try, there are several variations to consider and practice including:

- *Count*. This term refers to how long a breath or hold lasts. Try different counts to see what feels right!
- *Nose vs. mouth*. Inhaling (breathing in) or exhaling (breathing out) can be modified if you breathe through your nose or mouth. Try just your nose. Try just your mouth. Try breathing in through your nose and out through your mouth or the reverse. Breathing in through your nose and out through your mouth is a frequently referenced approach, but again, try variations and see what feels right.
- *Position*. When sitting, try sitting cross-legged. Or try laying down flat or with your feet on the ground.
- *Hand position*. Ideally, when breathing in, the lungs should expand and as a result, the abdomen should expand. When exhaling, the lungs should empty or deflate, and the abdomen should come in. To help with this, try placing a hand on the abdomen or one hand on the abdomen and one hand on the chest.

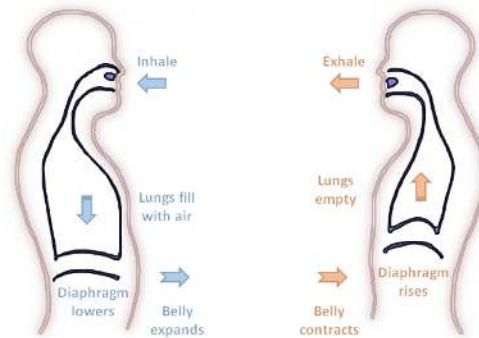


Figure 3.1: Diagram for deep breathing exercises. (Illustration by Remedial Class from Flickr.)

Now, take a few minutes to try each of the following exercises, considering different variations as discussed above.

Breathing Technique #1: Box breathing/Square breathing/Equal inhale exhale:

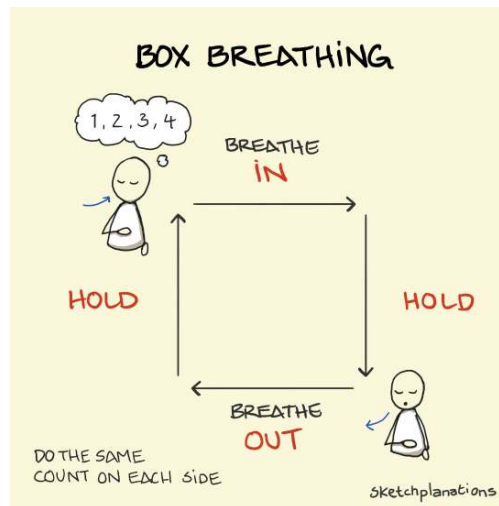


Figure 3.2: A person demonstrates breathing in, holding breath, breathing out, holding breath, counting four on each side around the side of a box. Also called square breathing: breathe in, hold, breathe out, hold. (Illustration by Sketchplanations.)

1. Breathe in for a count (such as 2, 4, or 6) that feels comfortable.
2. Hold breath for the same count as step 1 (2, 4, 6).
3. Breathe out for the same count as step 1 (2, 4, 6).
4. Hold breath for the same count as step 1.
5. Repeat.

Breathing Technique #2: Extended exhale/Skewed pattern:

1. Breathe in through the nose for a count (try 4).
2. Breathe out through the mouth for double the count (try 8).
3. Repeat.

Breathing Technique #3: 4-7-8 breathing

1. Breathe in your nose for 4 seconds.
2. Hold your breath for 7 seconds.
3. Breathe out of your mouth for 8 seconds.
4. Repeat 3 to 5 times.

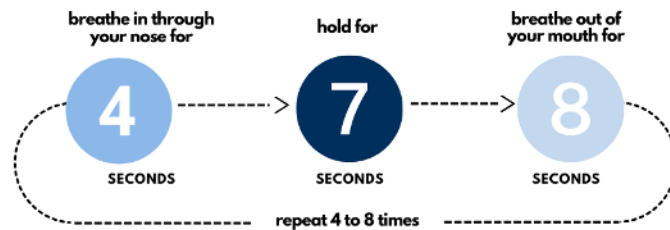


Figure 3.2: Diagram for 4-7-8 Breathing Technique. (Illustration by Michelle VanderWoude, CC BY.)

Breathing Technique #4: Pursed lip breathing

1. Breathe in for a count (try 2) through your nose with your mouth closed.
2. Hold breath.
3. Pucker/purse your lips, such as when trying to whistle, and blow out through your lips for a count longer than your inhale (try 4 or 6).
4. Repeat.



Video 3.1: Demonstration of pursed lip breathing. ("Pursed Lip Breathing" by BreatheBetterwithElizabeth on YouTube.)

Breathing Technique #5: Alternate nostril breathing/Nadi Shodhana Pranayama:

1. Using your right hand, close your right nostril with your thumb. Breathe in left nostril for a 4 count.
2. Close left nostril with your right ring and pinkie fingers (both nostrils briefly closed as you switch).
3. Open right nostril and breathe out for a 6 count.
4. Breathe in right nostril for a 4 count.
5. Close right nostril with your thumb (both nostrils briefly closed as you switch).
6. Open left nostril and breathe out for a 6 count.



Video 3.2: Demonstration of alternate nostril breathing. ("Alternate Nostril Breathing - Yoga Technique" by intosport on YouTube.)

Alternatives/Variations

- 5-finger breathing
- Mindful breathing
- Lion's breath breathing
- Heart rate control

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 3.1

Incorporate breathwork for a minimum of 5 minutes at a time, three times a day. Aim to do a breathwork activity in the morning, afternoon, and evening. An easy way to make this happen is planning it as part of the morning routine (such as right after brushing your teeth), before lunch, and before bed. Try to stick to a schedule and be intentional about noticing your physical and mental state before and after each session.

In addition to the three scheduled sessions each day, look for other opportunities to incorporate breathwork. If there is a moment of increased stress, such as in traffic at a long red light or during a classroom exam, try a breathing activity and note how it feels to use in a time of need.

As you practice breathwork, experiment with different counts, postures, and techniques. Notice how these affect your relaxation state.

At least once this week, try teaching a breathing pattern to another person. Notice how it feels to teach the activity and perform it with another person.

Reflection questions:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when using breathwork this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/ or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel with breathwork exercises?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience using breathwork?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for breathwork?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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4: Yoga

Background

One of my favorite aspects of teaching this course with students is the element of surprise. In its original form, students attend this course without any knowledge of what their weekly wellness experience will include. Sometimes they try and guess what is planned for the following week based on our meeting location or what materials/attire are required. Once, after reminding students to wear comfortable athletic clothing and bring a towel or mat, a student exclaimed with apprehension, “We’re not doing yoga, are we? Because I can’t do yoga.” This comment brought me back to my college years and my first experience with yoga. After a particularly stressful week, I attended a free yoga class at the fitness center hoping for a calming experience. Instead, I spent most of the hour tangled in frustration, twisting my body into seemingly impossible poses while trying to quiet my mind and focus on my breath. It didn’t feel relaxing, and it didn’t feel like meaningful exercise. After that solitary exasperated attempt, I decided yoga was not for me.

A decade later, as a health care provider who was struggling with anxiety and burnout, I began searching for a form of exercise that could bring healing to both my mind and body. In my search, I couldn’t ignore the overwhelming evidence for yoga as a remedy for mental and physical exhaustion. Just related to how yoga increases health and wellness for health care workers, I discovered a study that found that an 8-week yoga intervention for nurses led to significantly higher rates of self-care and a decrease in levels of emotional exhaustion ([Alexander et al., 2015](#)). Similarly, a 4-week yoga and mindfulness intervention among health care workers demonstrated significantly lower rates of anxiety ([La Torre et al., 2020](#)). And the benefits of yoga are not limited to mental health and well-being. For further evidence about the transformative power of yoga for managing stress, pain, chronic disease, and sleep problems (to name a few!), read this article from the [National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health](#) (2020).

If you are considering taking the leap and trying yoga as a wellness technique (and I hope you are!), you might be thinking, “What exactly is yoga?” While it’s widely known that yoga got its start as a spiritual practice in ancient India, yoga as it is practiced in the United States combines physical postures with meditation and breathing techniques ([National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health, 2023](#)). The primary goal of yoga is difficult to define, but has been described as the release of inner conflict and the achievement of a quiet mind or inner peace ([Chowdhury, n.d.](#)).

Another key aspect of yoga is its connection with the divine. While yoga’s historical roots are in Buddhism, the practice itself can be approached from a Christian perspective. For believers, yoga can be a time of prayer, reflection, and worship. It is an opportunity to focus our minds on God while caring for the body He created. In this way, yoga does not have to be a religious departure from Christianity—it can be a physical and spiritual discipline that draws us closer to God.

By this point, you may have guessed that I decided to give yoga another chance and this time around, I stuck with it. For beginners, here are some tips that I use in my own practice and shared with my anxious student during that first yoga session:

- **Yoga feels different for every person.** Listen to your body and mind. If you’re not ready or able to strike a certain pose, modify, and do what you can. Quieting your thoughts and connecting your mind and body is more important than pushing your physical limit.
- **Allow yourself the gift of vulnerability.** In the rush of daily life, pausing to focus on your inner thoughts can feel uncomfortable or intimidating. Yoga offers a safe space to slow down, check in with yourself, and work through the stressors you carry.
- **Keep an open mind and do not limit yourself.** Remember the student who was once terrified to try yoga? By the end of this wellness course, her final reflection revealed that yoga had become the primary self-care strategy she used to manage her stress throughout the busy semester. She planned to continue to use it moving forward. Maybe that will be your story too?

Activity

Before beginning yoga, it is important to note that mindful breathing during the physical movements of yoga is essential to this experience. The module on breathwork provides a strong foundation for yoga practice and many of the principles of breathwork are used throughout this exercise. For this reason, it is suggested that the module on breathwork be completed or revisited before engaging with yoga. For added practice on breathing during yoga, refer to the video entitled “Focal Points for Breathing in Yoga” located under the section on Alternatives/Variations.

Please note that if you have any concerns about your own physical activity, consult with your healthcare provider.



Figure 4.1: Incorporating yoga into your routine promotes wellness. (Photo by Yan Krukau from Pexels.)

Materials Suggested

1. Comfortable, breathable clothing is suggested, but not required.
2. Bare feet
3. Towel, exercise mat, or yoga mat
4. Open floor space large enough to accommodate the size of your yoga mat
5. Small throw pillow or a small, folded blanket
Note: These materials are optional, but may be helpful for beginners or those with limited flexibility to achieve postures or stretches with comfort.
6. Water
7. Video or written instructions to guide your practice
8. Open mind that is prepared to try something new

Directions

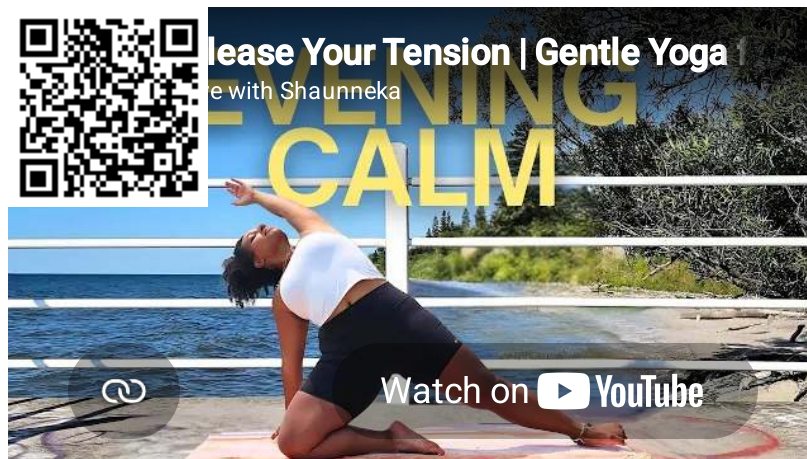
1. *Prepare your space:* Gather suggested materials, limit distractions (silence your phone from outside interruptions and turn off notifications), and choose a quiet environment. This type of setting is ideal to focus on thoughts, breath, and movement.
 2. *Choose a resource:* Select one of the suggested videos or articles about beginner yoga practice listed below and follow along. You may also choose your own video. Just search YouTube for "beginner yoga" videos that are around 20-30 minutes in length. If it feels too challenging, don't hesitate to try another video that feels like the right fit for you.
 3. *Engage in yoga:* Try it out!
 4. *Reflect on the experience:* Note how you feel before and after each session, paying attention to your mood as well as the energy of your body. For additional insight, record your heart rate and respiratory rate before and after each session.
-



Video 4.1: Yoga For Complete Beginners. ("Yoga For Complete Beginners - 20 Minute Home Yoga Workout" by Yoga With Adriene from YouTube.)



Video 4.2: Yoga For Anxiety. ("Yoga For Anxiety - 20 Minute Practice - Yoga With Adriene" by Yoga With Adriene from YouTube.)



Video 4.3: Yoga For Relaxation. ("20 Min Seated Yoga Flow for Deep Relaxation & Stress Relief | The Perfect Evening Practice!" by Move with Shaunneka from YouTube.)

The Beginner's Guide to Home Yoga Practice: As the title suggests, this beginner's guide from Yoga International offers tips that include setting an intention for your yoga practice and incorporating 8 yoga poses (with accompanying directions and images) into an easy 10-minute session.

[8 Best Yoga Poses for Beginners](#): This article from Yoga Journal catalogs beginner yoga poses with detailed “How to” instructions.

Alternatives/Variations



Video 4.4: Breathing in Yoga. ("Focal Points for Breathing in Yoga" by Antara Yoga from YouTube.)

Module on Breathwork

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 4.1

Remember that yoga is a unique wellness technique because it intentionally aims to unite the mind, body, and spirit. It is challenging to achieve this type of connection with only one session. For this reason, setting a goal to practice yoga for three or four sessions this week allows the body to gain some muscle memory in the movements while making space for the mind and spirit to participate in the yoga practice.

Reflection Questions:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when doing yoga this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel with yoga exercises?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience using yoga?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for yoga?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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5: Coloring

Background

Have you ever been so absorbed in a task that you lost track of time and everything else seemed to fade away? In those moments, the body and mind are fully engaged in the present, often accompanied by a sense of deep satisfaction and peace ([Psychology Today, n.d.](#)). This experience is known as flow state. More casually, this phenomenon is described as being 'in the zone,' as when a person is immersed in an activity that requires complete concentration. Flow state is desirable not only because it enhances productivity, but also because it helps reduce stress and anxiety ([Flett et al., 2017](#)). For many, moments of flow can also feel deeply spiritual, providing a sense of connection to something greater than oneself. In Christian practice, this aligns with experiences of being present with God through prayer. Professionals, artists, and athletes are just a few groups who intentionally cultivate flow to optimize their roles, crafts, or performances.

So how does flow state work, and how can you achieve it? The answer lies in neuroscience. When a person experiences the deep mind-body connection of flow, the brain releases *dopamine*, a neurotransmitter associated with pleasure, motivation, and relaxation ([Ranes, 2025](#)). This positive chemical response has led researchers to explore interventions that nurture flow for individuals facing high levels of daily stress, like health care workers or those in other helping professions.

One popular intervention that promotes flow state is coloring ([Jakobsson Støre & Jakobsson, 2022](#)). Although it may seem simple, coloring is a well-researched activity with proven health benefits. These include a reduction in anxiety and depression in addition to an increase in mindfulness, enjoyment, and creativity ([Flett et al., 2017](#); [Flicker et al., 2025](#); [Holt et al., 2019](#)). For health care workers such as nurses, recent research shows a significant decrease in stress symptoms after completing a structured coloring intervention ([Daly et al., 2024](#); [Kaplow et al., 2025](#)). Coloring is also an appealing coping strategy because it is affordable, readily available, and easy to practice.

Activity

Today you will be coloring. But not just any coloring of your favorite Disney princess or comic superhero, but a specific type of coloring called *mandala coloring*.

What is a mandala? A mandala is a circular geometric design made of repeating shapes and patterns.

Why choose a mandala design for a coloring activity? Research suggests that coloring a mandala shape provides a clearly defined goal, which supports entry into flow state ([Jakobsson Støre & Jakobsson, 2022](#)).



Figure 5.1: A mandala taken from the [coloring book Magic Mandalas](#). (Illustration by Peaksell from Wikimedia Commons.)

Materials Suggested

Coloring is an outlet for creativity and emotional expression. As you choose your materials, pay attention to how you are feeling and select colors or patterns that express your current mood. If you wish to shift your mindset, select colors that inspire a positive intention for the day and invite a sense of calm.

1. A printed mandala. You can purchase mandala coloring books at a local discount or dollar store, however, they are also able to be freely printed from online. Some websites with free printable versions include:
 - [Crayola](#)
 - [Monday Mandala](#)
 - [Kelly Dietrich](#)
2. 3-5 colored pencils, crayons, or markers. Remember that repetition of color is part of the beauty of mandala art.
3. Quiet space.
4. Music (optional)

Directions

1. **Set up materials in a quiet space.** Choose an environment with minimal distractions to support deep concentration. This type of calm setting helps promote achievement of flow state.
2. **Select a time frame for your activity.** Most research studies utilize a coloring intervention of 15-20 minutes. This amount of time may be necessary to achieve flow state and attain the physiologic benefits (like reduction of anxiety and stress) that come from coloring.
3. **Begin coloring.** The strategy for coloring a mandala is highly individualized. Suggestions include coloring from center to outer ring, coloring wedge by wedge or one “slice” at a time, or filling similar shapes with the same color and then moving on to the next color. You can watch this quick tutorial of how to color a mandala



Video 5.1: How to color a mandala. ("Basic tutorial for beginners on how to color a Mandala (Art Lesson 128)" by Mandala Art by Maria Hajj from YouTube.)

4. **Notice your body tension throughout the activity.** Pay attention to your posture and any tightness in your neck or shoulders. If you feel tension, consciously relax those areas and take a few deep breaths. You may find it helpful to set a timer every 4-5 minutes as a reminder to check in and release tension.
5. **Have fun.** There is no “right” way to color a mandala. The process and activity of coloring is the reward.

Alternatives/Variations

These activities may also foster flow state:

- Drawing or sketching
- Painting
- Sculpting
- Puzzles
- Journaling or creative writing

- Dancing
- Yoga

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 5.1

Spend 15-20 minutes at least 3-4 times this week coloring a mandala. As you color, pay attention to your thoughts, feelings, and any tension in your body. Choose colors that reflect your current mood or help set a positive intention for the day. You may also play soft music to enhance focus and relaxation. After each session, take a moment to reflect on how the activity influenced you physically, mentally, and spiritually.

Reflection Questions:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when coloring this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel when coloring?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience when coloring?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for coloring?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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6: Walk in Nature

Background

Have you ever spent some time sitting in nature surrounded by trees and found yourself feeling better? You may have actually been participating in the practice of *forest bathing* without even knowing it. Don't be alarmed - forest bathing has nothing to do with cleaning oneself in a natural stream or pond. Rather, forest bathing (also called *shinrin-yoku* in Japanese) is a meditative practice characterized by walking in a forest at a non-tiring pace and contemplating the natural environment ([Antonelli et al., 2019](#)). It is more than just walking in the woods though. It is the conscious and contemplative practice of using your senses - think sight, smell, feel, and sound - while being immersed in the forest ([Global Wellness Institute, n.d.](#)). Peer-reviewed evidence supports that forest bathing is capable of significantly reducing stress levels, especially stress due to studying and working activities ([Antonelli et al., 2021](#)). In general, the shorter the forest bathing session is, the smaller the effect of the intervention, but even brief visits to the forest were shown to impact individual well-being ([Antonelli et al., 2021](#)). In a separate study, 15 minutes of forest bathing showed positive short-term effects on mental health including reduction in stress and anxiety ([Kotera et al., 2020](#)).

The previous module on [Breathwork](#) presented how breath is a gift from God. In this module, we can expand the list of gifts from God by directly linking our breath to trees. Think about the perfect partnership that God created between humans and trees. Humans breath out carbon dioxide. Trees use the carbon dioxide and generate oxygen that is in return essential to human life. Humans are designed to work together with nature for the very air we share! Genesis 1:1 states: "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth", so this week, let us go enjoy that earth!



Figure 6.1: Forest bathing is a meditative practice. (Photo by Alex Moliski from Pexels.)

Activity

This week's activity asks you to take a trip into nature to explore and experience the world around you. Remember that the focus of this practice is not on getting a vigorous workout or hike in, but on becoming more aware of your surroundings and being curious about the world around you. To get a better sense of how to begin forest bathing and what to focus on, check out this [beginner's guide](#) from Forestry England.

Materials Suggested

- Comfortable clothing for being outdoors
- Good walking shoes

Directions

Identify a safe place to go for a walk *in a forest*. Ideally this is an actual forest versus an urban park or a cluster of trees in your backyard. Surround yourself by as many trees as possible. This can be done by oneself or with others. For the first fifteen minutes of the walk, direct your attention fully to your surroundings. Avoid conversations and use of audio. Prompt yourself to consider the following questions:

- What do I see?
- What do I hear?
- What do I smell?
- What do I taste?
- What do I feel?

As other thoughts enter your mind, gently push them aside and redirect to focus on nature and your surroundings. It may also be helpful to connect back to the breathwork you experienced earlier in the course and try some of those breathing techniques in the forest as well.

At the end of the set amount of time (aim for 15 minutes minimum), take a moment to reflect on how you feel. Then either continue your walk and engage your senses in nature or transition to a time of conversation with others or use audio (such as music, audiobooks, or podcasts). Note how these different activities each effect you. Consider when each might be useful to implement into your self-care.

Alternatives/Variations

- Grounding/Earthing - standing barefoot and/or making physical contact with the earth's surface
- Visiting a botanical gardens or greenhouse
- Exploring a meadow

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 6.1

Aim to spend a total of 2 hours in the forest this week. This can be one long visit/walk or broken down into smaller visits over multiple days. With the visit, be deliberate in considering the how you felt while you were in the forest, and how you felt after.

Reflection Questions:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when doing forest bathing this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual)
2. What benefits did you feel with forest bathing?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience doing forest bathing?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for forest bathing?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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7: Reading for Fun

Background

Remembering sitting on the floor in your elementary school classroom and having the teacher read a story to you out loud? How did it feel? Does the image that comes to mind bring a sense of relaxation or comfort?

Reading for pleasure has been associated with many health benefits. One recent study found that recreational reading for college students was associated with reduced psychological distress and improved sleep over the school year (Levine et al., 2020). Critical thinking, a skill important in many college classrooms, was found to increase when students engaged in voluntary reading (Hawkins, 2012) with brain connectivity improving as well when you read a novel (Berns et al., 2013). Psychologically, a different study found that students who emotionally connected with a fictitious story were more empathetic after reading (Bal & Veltkamp, 2013). Another study presented data that reading books was associated with a 20% reduction in mortality when compared to others who did not read books (Bavishi et al., 2016).

Aside from personal health benefits, reading also is a way to expand one's own understanding of the world around them. Proverbs 4:7 (ESV) reads: "The beginning of wisdom is this: Get wisdom, and whatever you get, get insight." Isn't reading a way to get both wisdom and insight? In the helping professions, think of all the different points of views books can offer, and how that can translate to caring for others.

While there is research that provides evidence-based backing for reading for pleasure, there is a gap in evidenced-based literature regarding the potential benefits specific to nurses and other helping professions. Additional research could expand knowledge specific to how reading can help nurses and if different types of reading materials are associated with different benefits!



Figure 7.1: Reading for pleasure has many benefits. (Photo by Kaboompics.com from Pexels.)

Activity

This activity will involve you doing some reading on your own - not anything related to your academic studies, but finding something to read that you find enjoyable. For some, this could be a young adult book that you read while growing up. Or it could be a graphic novel or comic book. Or a book of poetry or a play. Or a classic novel that you have wanted to read for years. There are many different possibilities that can take you on a journey of imagination away from the daily grind of your academic studies.

Materials Suggested

- Any book of choice

- *Note:* If this activity is being done in a class, consider inviting a guest speaker from the Library or English Education department to discuss some book recommendations

Directions

For a classroom setting:

1. Start with a discussion or reflection on how it feels to settle into reading. Share or think about memories of when a book was read out loud to you as a child or when you were able to escape to a different world reading a book.
2. Share brief book recommendations that include a 1-minute summary and why that book is recommended. Aim for a variety of options!
3. After picking a text with a strong chapter for the group to hear, settle into comfortable positions that promote relaxation. **Read the chapter out loud** (or if needed, play an audiobook). Note the book chosen can be from any background! Children's or young adult literature can work just as well as adult fiction.

For an individual:

1. Reflect on how it feels to settle into reading. Think about memories of when a book was read out loud to you as a child or when you were able to escape to a different world reading a book.
2. Spend some time (set a limit) looking up book recommendations to find a book to read this week. Use a book app like [GoodReads](#) or [Story Graph](#) to look at book options based on your preferences. Or consider a book off of the [Great American Read list](#).
 - *Note:* It can be a physical book or an audiobook of any genre!
3. For at least 30 minutes, settle into the book. Avoid other distractions (turn your phone off) or multi-tasking. Set a timer. When done, reflect on how you feel.

Alternatives/Variations

- Read out loud to others (volunteer at a school or assisted living facility)
- Read the Bible

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 7.1

Read something not assigned for a class, for at least 1 hour this week. Consider trying reading at different times to assess how it makes you feel.

- Does reading for 5 minutes in the morning help you start your day more relaxed?
- Does reading a chapter before bed help you sleep better?
- Does listening to an audiobook during a drive make you feel different than listening to the radio or other materials?

Be creative to overcome barriers. If you have a hard time stopping reading at night, consider a book with short chapters to make it easier to set a stop point. Keep your book with you and instead of spending a few minutes scrolling on your phone, open your book during free time.

Reflection Questions

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when reading for fun this week:
Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel when reading for fun?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience when reading for fun?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for reading for fun?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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8: Journaling

Background

Did you know that current research suggests that human beings have more than 6,000 thoughts per day? (Tseng & Poppenk, 2020). This statistic demonstrates our brain's amazing ability to engage with a complex world, but it also reveals the busyness and intricacy of our own minds. Have you ever felt like your brain is a Google search bar, with 10-15 open tabs at any given moment? Or maybe you are on autopilot, juggling a never-ending to-do list alongside responsibilities at work, school, and home. When we are bouncing from one thought to another to keep up with the current fast-paced culture, when does the mind have the opportunity to pause, reflect, and truly learn from life's experiences?

One answer to this question is through the wellness activity of journaling. Journaling is the intentional practice of writing down your thoughts and feelings to gain insight into your past, present, and future life experiences. This simple act of self-awareness has powerful, wide-ranging health benefits like lowering blood pressure, boosting immune system response, and reducing symptoms of anxiety and depression (Baikie & Wilhelm, 2005; Krpan et al., 2013; Smyth et al., 2018). Moreover, a 2023 systematic review of workplace interventions to improve well-being among health care workers concluded that gratitude journaling was an effective tool for reducing stress and depressive symptoms as well as increasing feelings of happiness (Cohen et al., 2023). Regular journaling has even been shown to decrease symptoms of burnout and trauma compassion fatigue in nurses (Dimitroff et al., 2017).

So how does the small act of journal writing lead to big changes in physical, mental, and emotional well-being? The short answer is mindfulness. By sitting down and writing your thoughts, your mind remains focused on your present situation. Even if you are writing about past experiences or fears of the future, you are naming, analyzing, and responding to current thoughts or feelings. This practice of intentional reflection is essential for self-growth and well-being.

Activity

Journaling can offer a window into your mental state and a private space to process your thoughts and feelings. It can help you regulate your emotions, track personal growth, and provide clarity in setting goals.



Figure 8.1: Writing your thoughts helps you remain focused on your current situation. (Photo by Alina Vilchenko from Pexels.)

Materials Suggested

Because journaling is a form of self-expression, the materials you select should reflect your preferences and personality. Feel free to get as creative as you want and choose supplies with various colors and textures. If a digital journal entry is preferred, then consider logging your entries in a different color or style font.

- Writing utensil
- Paper or notebook
- Computer or tablet (if doing the activity digitally)

Directions

1. **Choose a space that is free from distraction and promotes feelings of relaxation and comfort.** Journaling is an introspective and reflective practice. The ideal setting for this activity allows your mind time and space to explore personal thoughts and feelings without interruption. This could be in a quiet room in your home, sitting in your car, or traveling on public transportation. It could be at a local coffee shop or even a breakroom during a shift at work. One of the best parts of this wellness activity is that it can be done at any time and at any place as long as it works for you.
2. **Choose a time frame for your activity.** Set a goal for the minimum amount of time you want to journal, but allow yourself the flexibility to journal beyond that time limit. Journal writing sessions of 10-20 minutes in length are most common, but health benefits are possible with as little as two minutes of daily journal time ([Burton & King, 2008](#)). Journaling time may vary depending on your daily circumstances and wellness needs.
3. **Begin journaling.** Write your thoughts and feelings down on paper or type them on your tablet/computer. You can write down whatever flows naturally from your mind in this moment or choose from one of the following writing prompts suggested by *Psychology Today* ([Martin, 2024](#)):
 - What are you worried about right now?
 - What events happened today and how do you feel about them?
 - What are three things that you are grateful for and why?
 - What is a situation that you can't stop thinking about?
 - Discuss a happy memory and reflect on why it makes you happy.
 - Write about something that makes you feel angry, sad, or afraid.
 - Discuss a problem that you want to solve and possible solutions.
4. **Consider using a reflective model.** The [Gibbs Model of Reflection \(1988\)](#) is a helpful tool for journal writing. This six-stage cycle guides the exploration of an individual's experience with emphasis on fostering personal and professional development ([Butler, 2024](#)).

Alternatives/Variations

Consider these different forms of writing to express your thoughts and feelings. Review the associated links to gain deeper insight into these variations on journaling.

1. **Reflective writing**
 - [Reflective Practice Toolkit, University of Cambridge](#)
 - [Reflective Writing, Australian National University](#)
2. **Gratitude journaling**
 - [Gratitude Journal: 35 Ideas for Getting Started](#)
3. Learn How to Write Expressively (and heal yourself):



Video 8.1: Learn how to write expressively. ("[Nelda Shorts | James Pennebaker | How to write expressively and heal yourself](#)" by [Nelda Studios from YouTube](#).)

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 8.1

Review your daily and weekly schedule to dedicate time for journaling. The goal is to write a daily journal entry. The timing of this activity should be the best fit for your schedule. For some people, this might look like journaling at the same time every day with your morning coffee or before bed. For others, the time for journal writing will vary depending on when your schedule allows for those precious moments of solitude. Whenever you find the time, the most important part of journaling is committing consistent minutes each day to the practice of allowing thoughts and feelings to flow from the mind to paper (or computer/tablet).

Reflection Questions

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when journaling this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel when journaling?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience when journaling?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for journaling?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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9: Sleep

Background

Sleep is an essential part of life. The [National Sleep Foundation \(2020\)](#) recommends that the average adult should sleep 7-9 hours per night. People who get the recommended amount of sleep are more likely to flourish in their day-to-day life ([National Sleep Foundation, 2025](#)). Despite knowing how important sleep is, many helping professionals and college students struggle to get adequate sleep. 77.4% of one sample population of hundreds of nurses had a poor quality of sleep, with night shift nurses having more sleep problems than others ([Khatony et al., 2020](#)). In a different study, 87% of intensive care unit (ICU) nurses experienced poor sleep quality which affected their professional quality of life ([Mansouri et al., 2025](#)). Related to college students, 60% of surveyed students reported experiencing sleep disturbances which affected their physical and psychological health ([Lund et al., 2010](#)).

Many factors can impact sleep. One significant factor is the use of electronic devices. A study reported that 97.3% of medical students used a blue light-emitting device at bedtime with a mean duration of screen time being 1 hour and 50 minutes per night. More than half of the students had their sleep interrupted to check messages ([Jniene et al., 2019](#)). Healthcare workers are at risk for sleeping disturbances for several reasons including shift work, work-related schedules, stress, and the type of care they provide for other people. Other factors that can impact sleep include one's activity level, alcohol use, caffeine use, stress, and environment.

In the past decade, both the American Nurses Association and the American Academy of Nursing have released position statements on the importance of addressing fatigue, sleep, work, and safety for nurses ([Weaver, 2024](#)). Research supports that there is a strong link between sleep disturbances and burnout in nurses ([Ren et al., 2025](#)). Nurses who are not getting enough sleep are also at increased risk for many infections like the common cold, pneumonia, bronchitis, sinusitis, and gastrointestinal infections ([Hartveit Hosøy et al., 2025](#)). Sleep also impacts the care that healthcare workers can provide others, directly impacting safety for both the nurse and patient as well as overall quality of care. Likewise, poor sleep has many negative impacts on students, including impaired memory, reduced cognitive function, decreased motivation and focus, and increased stress and anxiety ([TrueLearn, 2025](#)). Some good news is that while the average college student has a significant need for improved sleep, this population is also more responsive to sleep related interventions ([Saruhanjan, et al., 2020](#)).

How does God feel about sleep? In Genesis 2:2 (NLT), we read that "On the seventh day God had finished his work of creation, so he rested from all his work." Even God rested! With all that in mind, this week the focus is on sleep!

Activity

Who doesn't love a good sleep? This week, we are going to assess the length and quality of our sleep using the Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index (PSQI). This evidence-based assessment helps people measure their sleep quality. From these results, you will identify ways to modify your sleeping patterns. This will mostly be done by setting some sleep-related goals for the week and tracking them. And hopefully, with these modifications, your overall wellness will be improved as well!



Figure 9.1: Sleep is essential for your wellbeing. (Photo by Jasmine Pang from Pexels.)

Materials Suggested

- Paper, pencil, or electronic device for documenting
- *Optional:* Sleep aids such as eye masks, ear plugs, noise machines, or sleep tracking devices like a smart watch

Directions

Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index

The Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index ([Buysse et al., 1989](#)) is an evidence-based assessment that helps people measure their sleep quality. It contains 19 questions (plus a few more if you sleep with a partner) with a scoring rubric as well.

Take the assessment using one of the links below:

- [Electronic access to Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index \(PSQI\)](#) (recommended for ease of use of results)
- [Print version of Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index PSQI](#)

Note: If you use the print version, you will also need the [scoring rubric](#) as well.

For both the digital or print version, a final PSQI score less than or equal to ($\leq$) 5 is associated with good sleep quality. A score greater than ($>$) 5 is associated with poor sleep quality.

Evidence-Based Sleep Interventions

There are numerous evidence-based interventions that can help with the quality of your sleep. An example of a research study that investigated different inventions tested relaxation, music therapy, and the use of earplugs/eye masks ([Ashghab et al., 2024](#)). But there are many more options to consider!

This exercise will help you set a few goals for the week. Consider each of the following interventions and what it could look like for you to try it out this week. If it is something you want to commit to, place a checkmark in the check column. As you go, write specific goals for you and your plans as appropriate, such as "Last coffee for the day is at 12pm" or "Set bed time alert for 11pm."

This chart is also available as a PDF download: [Sleep Interventions](#)

Intervention	Check	Comments about specific goal
Physical Environment		
Turn off all lights when going to sleep		
Change lights remaining on in sleeping area to red-light or non-blue light		
Adjust electronic devices off of blue light for night use		
Regulate room temperature		
Insert ear plugs		
Wear an eye mask		
Aromatherapy: Use lavender or damask rose extract		
Sleep with phone away from bed		
Set phone to "sleep mode" each night		
Turn off all non-essential notifications for phone apps		
Activity Considerations		
Set a consistent time to go to bed with a phone alert for this time		

Set a consistent time to wake up		
Avoid napping during the day		
No caffeine for at least 6 hours before bed		
No alcohol for at least 3 hours before bed		
Work out for at least 20 minutes during the day at least 1 hour before bed		
No use of blue light electronics (phone, tablet, computer, TV) at least 1 hour before bed		
Start a routine that excludes electronics or TV for consistent approach to bedtime		
Relaxation Techniques		
Pre-bed muscle relaxation or body scan		
Sleep yoga		
Sleep-focused meditation		
No going to bed feeling stressed, angry, upset, or nervous. Resolve feelings before getting into bed.		
No thinking, planning, or worrying in bed.		
Other		

Resources for Interventions

To assist you in coming up with some sleep interventions or learning more about the different interventions mentioned in the chart, here are some additional resources that may be of assistance (see [Gupta et al., 2023](#) for more specifics about many of these interventions):

Physical Environment:

- Temperature control: Regulate room temperature to personal preference for comfort
- Lighting control: Turn off all lights; use blackout curtains; wear an eye mask
- Sound control: Use ear plugs; use a sound/noise machine
- Different type of sheets
- Use aromatherapy like lavender or damask rose extract

Activity Considerations:

- Try to set a schedule that allows for a consistent time of going to bed and getting out of bed each day
- Avoid daytime napping or reduce the nap to less than 2 hours
- Avoid caffeine for at least 6 hours prior to bedtime ([Drake et al., 2013](#))
- Avoid alcohol at least 3 hours prior to bedtime or consider abstaining altogether ([Bryan & Singh, 2025](#))
- Avoid exercising to the point of sweating within 1 hour of going to bed; Keep track of when and how exercise impacts your sleep
- Avoid use of any blue light (phone, computer, tablets, TV) for at least 1 hour before bed

Relaxation Techniques:

- Avoid going to bed feeling stressed, angry, upset or nervous; try to avoid thinking, planning, or worrying in bed
- Apps/websites that can help you relax including *Calm*, *Balance*, relaxing music playlists on Spotify, Apple Music, or YouTube

- Muscle relaxation
- Body scan meditations



Video 9.1: 10 Minute Sleep Meditation. ("[10 Minute Sleep Meditation A Guided Talk Down Body Scan](#)" by Great Meditation from [YouTube](#).)



Video 9.2: 5 Minute Body Scan. ("[5 Minute Body Scan Meditation](#)" by Medistate Mind from [YouTube](#).)

- Sleep yoga:



Video 9.3: 8 Minute Evening Yoga. ("[8 Minute Evening Yoga - Wind Down & Chill Out Yoga](#)" by Yoga with Cassandra from [YouTube](#).)



Video 9.4: 5 Minute Yoga for Bedtime. ("5 min Yoga For Bedtime - Yoga Stretch For DEEP SLEEP" by Yoga with Cassandra from YouTube.)

- Sleep meditation or relaxation imagery through guided meditation



Video 9.5: Sleep Meditation. ("Guided 20 Minute Sleep Meditation" by Great Meditation from YouTube.)

- Spotify (note: account may be required for access):
 - [Guided Mediation for Deep Sleep](#)
 - [Guided Meditation for Restful Sleep](#)
 - [Guided Meditation for Restful Sleep](#)

See some of the previous modules that related to quality sleep:

- [Breathwork](#)
- [Yoga](#)
- [Walk in Nature](#)
- [Journaling](#)

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 9.1

After considering the different resources for intervention, write three different sleep goals that you can incorporate this week. In addition, you will be tracking and logging your sleep each day using a sleep diary. Fill out the sleep diary as directed each morning and night for one consecutive week.

[Print version of a Sleep Diary](#)

Reflection:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas with focusing on sleep this week: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel with focusing on sleep?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience focusing on sleep?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for focusing on sleep?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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10: Strength Training

Background

For many years, I worked as a labor and delivery nurse. It was a very physically demanding job. I could be on my feet for an entire 12- (or 14- or 16-) hour shift. I assist in heavy lifting to care for patients with limited mobility related to epidurals or surgery. Helping patients deliver might include holding a leg or working in an awkward position to meet the patient's needs. I witnessed and felt the toll that this type of work took on not only my body, but the other nurses around me. Unfortunately, many colleagues suffered from injuries, chronic back pain, and even sometimes the need for spinal surgery.

My experience is not unique. Nursing has been documented as the occupation with the highest prevalence of heavy lifting, which is noted as the most significant risk factor for the development of musculoskeletal injuries, especially to the lower back ([Tariq et al., 2023](#)). As such, it is no surprise that nurses have a higher-than-average risk of sustaining musculoskeletal problems related to their work. For a first hand story of a nurse lifting injury, you can read more in the article "[The nurse who could lift](#)" ([Jones, 2017](#)).

Nurses often engage in the actions of bending, reaching, extended periods of walking and standing, heavy lifting, and moving patients. These activities make nurses especially vulnerable to back injuries, fatigue, slips, trips, and falls ([Dressner & Kissinger, 2018](#)). In their report which used data from 2016, 27.7% (5,490 cases) of the days-away-from-work cases involving RNs resulted from injuries to the back and required a median recovery time of 7 days. These injuries occurred at an incidence rate greater than the rate of back injuries for all occupations ([Dressner & Kissinger, 2018](#)). Physicians and physical therapists also have been documented to have a prevalence of back issues, though not quite as high as nurses ([Tariq et al., 2023](#)).

These startling statistics should be used as a call for nurses to consider modifiable and non-modifiable risk factors for musculoskeletal injuries and preventative steps that can be taken proactively. Physical activity helps nurses reduce stress, build stamina, and inspire healthier lifestyles. While nurses often stay active throughout the day, many do not meet the recommended exercise guidelines ([American Nurses Association, n.d.](#)). Strength training is one highly impactful approach to helping prepare the body for the physical demands of nursing ([Barrington Orthopedic, 2021](#)). Strength training has numerous benefits that may include bone strengthening, weight management, quality of life improvement, chronic condition management, and even sharpened thinking skills ([Mayo Clinic, 2023](#)). Strength training can be done through different methods such as weight lifting or resistance training. Resistance training is defined as "a form of exercise that increases muscular strength and endurance by exercising a muscle or muscle group against external resistance" ([Cave, n.d., para. 2](#)). It is associated with improved blood pressure, glycemic index, lipids, and body composition. It also has been associated with enhanced sleep quality and reduced symptoms of depression and anxiety ([Paluch et al., 2023](#)). Similarly, weightlifting is a common form of exercise used to improve strength and power ([Morris et al., 2022](#)). While this training is often associated with athletes, there are definite benefits to consider for healthcare professionals with physically demanding jobs. Like so many other areas of wellness, research specific to the short- and long- term benefits of weightlifting and resistance training *specific to nurses or those in helping professions* is limited. However, there is plenty of evidence-based support for the health benefits of these activities to the general adult population.

When considering how important the body is as a tool for healthcare professionals, perhaps the Bible can provide further inspiration. 1 Corinthians 6:19-20 (NIV) reads: "Do you not know that your bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore, honor God with your bodies." Providing care for others as a healthcare worker seems like an excellent way to honor God with your body. Taking that one step further, providing care for your own body so that you can provide care for others seems like another excellent way to honor God with the gift that is your body. Let those words serve as motivation as you tackle this week's physical activity!

Activity

This week, you are going to move!! The goal is to complete a total body weightlifting circuit routine. If you are completely new to the gym/fitness center, that is okay! Do not stress. [Here are some tips](#) for nurses or others in helping professions who are just getting started in the gym ([Healthy Nurse, Healthy Nation, 2024](#)). Every fitness center should have personnel that are trained in the use of gym equipment and can help you get started. Don't be afraid to ask! Really, most people are happy to share their knowledge! Or consider asking a classmate, friend, or family member to join you for this week's activity.



Figure 10.1: The body is a temple. (Photo by The Lazy Artist Gallery from Pexels.)

Materials Suggested

1. Athletic shoes. Supportive footwear matters!
2. Athletic clothing: A loose-fitting T-shirt or tank top and shorts are recommended
3. A fitness center with weight training equipment
 - If you are a student, you are encouraged to explore your school's fitness facility.
 - If you do not have direct access to a fitness center as a student, explore what your community has to offer. Perhaps there is a local recreational center, community center, or fitness center that offers free trial memberships for the week.
 - If you do not have access to a fitness center, you can explore options to workout from home via free online resources. YouTube has a number of alternative options or paid-from-home fitness workouts (examples below). Make sure the workouts include a focus on strength training or muscle building, though, to differentiate from other activities like yoga, walking, biking, or running.

Directions

Please note that if you have any concerns about physical activity, consult your healthcare provider.

1. To start, do a 5 minute warm up which might include one of the following activities:
 - Brisk walking
 - Jog
 - Jumping jacks
 - Elliptical
2. Next, move to weights. You can either use [free weights](#) or [a machine](#). If you are not sure how to use either, do not be afraid to ask for help! If you are a beginner, you may also [benefit from more information about weight lifting](#).
3. You should pick at least one option from each of the major muscle groups. Start with a weight level that allows you to feel comfortable lifting that weight at least 10 times with proper form.
 - Each controlled movement is called a repetition (rep, for short).
 - Performing the controlled movement 10 times (or 10 reps) is considered 1 set.
 - After 1 set, you should take a short break (generally, 30-90 seconds depending on your goals).
 - The goal is to complete 3 sets (30 total reps) for each muscle group.
 - Once you have done three sets for all of the major muscle areas, you have completed a circuit.
 - If you are easily able to complete 10 reps for 3 sets, you might consider either increasing to 15 or 20 reps for a set or increasing the weight the next time you do a set.

For this week, you can record your weights and reps on the Weight Lifting Circuit Routine worksheet, available for PDF download:

▢ [Weight Lifting Circuit Routine worksheet](#)

Weight Lifting Circuit Routine						
Exercise:	Set 1		Set 2		Set 3	
CHEST	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Options:						
Bench Press						
Dumbbell flies						
BACK	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Options:						
Lat Pulldown						
Bent Over row						
Supermans						
LEG Options:	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Leg Press						
Leg Extension						
Leg Curl						
ABS Options:	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Crunches						
Decline Crunches						
ARM Options:	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Biceps curls						
Triceps extensions						
SHOULDER Options:	lbs	reps	lbs	reps	lbs	reps
Lateral Raises						
Front raises						

* pick at least ONE of the options for each body part
 * record the amount of weight used and repetitions completed for each exercise
 *3 sets of 10 reps - recommended

Figure 10.2: Weight Lifting Circuit Route. (Used with permission from Dr. Shari Jurgens.)

Tips for a successful strength training experience

- Gently stretch your muscles after completing your work out
- Make sure to drink lots of water and stay hydrated

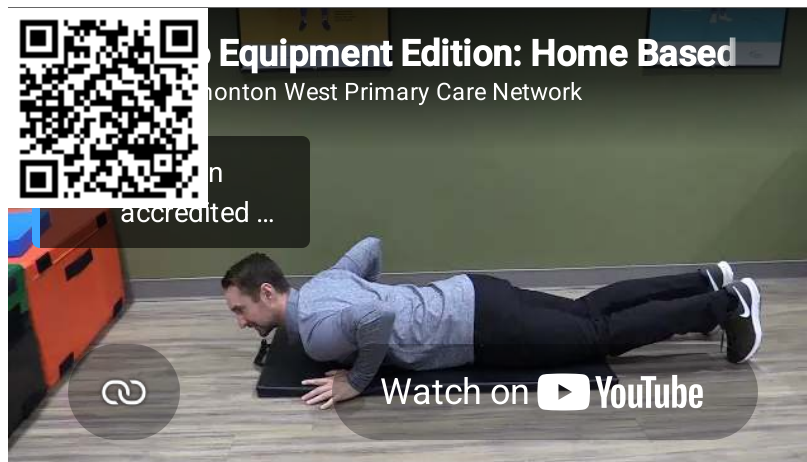
Alternatives/Variations

If a fitness center is not an option for you, here is an example of a weightlifting workout that you can do at home if you have access to some dumbbells.



Video 10.1: 30 Minute Dumbbell Workout. ("30 Min Full Body Dumbbell Workout for Beginners - Beginner Strength Training at Home with Weight" by HASfit on Youtube.)

If you don't have any equipment, check out these options for home-based resistance training:



Video 10.2: 30 Minute Dumbbell Workout. ("No Equipment Edition: Home Based Resistance Training" by Edmonton West Primary Care Network on YouTube.)



Video 10.3: Strength Workout for Beginners. (Strength Training for Beginners | Bodyweight Workout *NO EQUIPMENT* by Jenny J Fitness on YouTube.)

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 10.1

The goal for this week is to complete 3 circuit workouts. If you did one circuit during class today, congratulations! Look at your calendar and plan for two more sessions, scheduled at least 1 day apart. Track each of your sets with weight and reps and note how you feel during and after each session!

Reflection:

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas with strength training: Emotional, Environmental, Intellectual, Occupational, Physical, Social, and/or Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel with strength training?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience using strength training?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for strength training?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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11: Games

Background

Take a moment to imagine each of the following scenarios:

- Rolling a *Yahtzee* during game night
- Competing as part of a team in a sporting event
- Landing on "Free Parking" during a fierce round of *Monopoly*
- Laughing through a round of charades

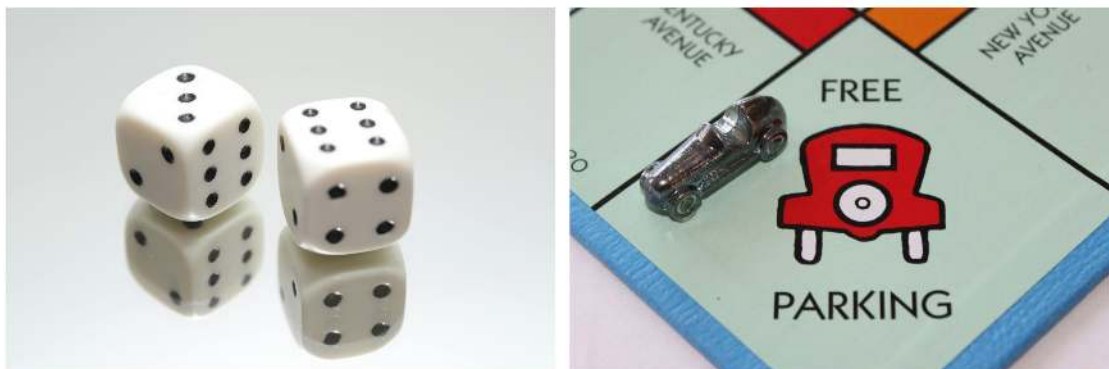


Figure 11.3: Playing games together can improve physical and psychological health. (Photos by [ClickerHappy from Pexels](#) (left), [Philip Taylor ptmoney.com from Flickr](#) (right).)

Did any of those scenarios bring to mind a positive memory? Hopefully one or two! All these scenarios have elements of social interaction through playing a game. The saying "fun and games" implies the innate connection between participating in games and finding joy. If you dig a little deeper into that concept, research shows that the health benefits of playing games are plentiful. Some of the benefits may come from the game itself, while other benefits may relate to participating in a social interaction.

Social interaction is important for health. Studies have shown that being socially active is associated with less stress and depression, lower blood pressure, smaller waist circumference and body mass index, and better overall cortisol levels ([Barbieri, 2021](#)). Social interaction, also identified as "social and community context", has been identified to be one of the five primary social determinants of health as defined by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention ([CDC, 2024](#)). These health determinants are non-medical factors that are most likely to influence health outcomes in the general population.

Games can be one specific approach to social interaction. In one recent study, data suggested that table-top, role-playing games can result in reduced general anxiety, social anxiety, and improved social skills ([Varrette et al., 2022](#)). A different 20-year, population-based study found the risk for dementia was 15% lower in participants who regularly participated in playing board games ([Dartigues et al., 2013](#)). A published systematic review incorporated 83 studies about "board games" and outlined health benefits that ranged from decreased heart rate variability and panic attacks to increased gray-matter in the brain and lower depression scores ([Nakao, 2019](#)). But board games are not the only game that showed positive effects. [Barbieri \(2021\)](#) reported that individuals who participated in organized sports self-reported that they had improved physical and psychological health.

"Health and games" is not as catchy to say as "fun and games", but the proof of the health benefits are impressive! And remember, people were designed by God as social beings. In Genesis 2:18 (NASB), "the Lord God said, 'It is not good for the man to be alone.'" In Matthew 18:20 (NIV), Jesus states that "where two or three gather in my name, there am I with them." Was Jesus talking about playing board games? No. Did God create Eve specifically to throw around an apple? Probably not! However, humans **were** created to be together and playing games can be just one potentially positive way to do that.

Activity

As you might be able to guess, today you will be playing a game of your choice. Games offer the opportunity for social interaction and the ability to learn life skills that can be applied in other areas of life. Whatever game is chosen, though, have fun!!

Materials Suggested

- A game of your choice
- A person or group of people to play your game with

Directions

Find another person or a group and play a game together! The only requirement is that it *must be with someone else* (no single-player Solitaire or playing a game on your phone!). It is recommended that you play the game in person, but if absolutely necessary there are apps or online games that can allow for live social interaction while playing with others.

The options for games are endless! A few favorites from a recent unofficial survey include:

- Dutch Blitz card game
- Sequence
- Candyland
- Jackbox
- Hilarium
- Kickball
- Tag

Remember that you can also play games that don't have a winner and loser (particularly if you either get too competitive or don't like competition). There are many cooperative games where you work together with others to achieve some task including:

- Pandemic
- Max
- Tower building
- Telephone
- 5-Word Story

Alternatives/Variations

- Gathering together to prepare a meal
- Being part of a team
- Taking a walk with friends

? Exercise 11.1

Weekly Recommendations/Homework

The activity this week is to play a game. Try to schedule at least two additional social gatherings around a game this week or you can achieve this through one longer game session. If doing more than one session, try a different game and see if that makes any difference on how you feel.

Reflection Questions

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when gathering for a game:
 - Emotional
 - Environmental
 - Intellectual
 - Occupational
 - Physical
 - Social
 - Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel while playing a game with others?
3. What, if any, barriers did you experience when playing a game with others?
4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for playing a game with others?
5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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12: Choose Your Own Adventure

The previous chapters have covered a variety of evidenced-based wellness activities. However, it would be impossible to cover ALL the options for wellness and self-care that are available in the world! The purpose of this chapter is to provide a transition space for you to follow the same structure as the previous activities, but to explore an activity that has not been covered yet. By doing this, you get to experience and learn about another activity of your choosing, but you also begin the evolution of continuing to explore your wellness without exact directions of what is required of you for that week.

How do you know what activity to consider this week? Perhaps there is an activity that you have been curious about or have considered trying. Or maybe there is something that you have never wanted to do, but now you feel ready to step outside of your comfort zone and do something completely different! This week, that choice is yours!

Activity

For each of the previous modules, we have included a foundation of evidence-based practice that shows the wellness benefits for the chosen activity. With modern technology, this might seem pretty easy, but sometimes the "ease" of information can actually make finding evidence-based information harder to discern. Not all evidence is created equal!

Finding good information begins with finding authoritative and credible research, often called **peer-reviewed research**. Peer-reviewed research is exactly what it sounds like - research that other scholars (or peers) in the field review to ensure that information and data is accurate. Research that goes through this process is considered higher quality and more credible than information that is not peer-reviewed. This does not mean, though, that you should avoid all non-peer-reviewed research when searching for evidence-based information. There are some really good and helpful websites that are not peer-reviewed. However, the majority of information around your activity should be strongly rooted in evidence-based practice.

There are a few ways you can go about finding evidence-based information. If you are a current college student, you most likely have access to research databases through your institution's library. If you have never been shown how to access databases, don't be afraid to ask your librarian for help! Biased opinion here, but I think librarians are pretty nice and a great resource when help is needed!

Some examples of subscription databases for finding wellness-related research could include:

- CINAHL (Cumulative Index to Nursing and Allied Health Literature)
- MEDLINE
- Cochrane Library
- OVID

If you are not a current student, don't worry! [PubMed](#) is a freely-available, online database that contains wellness-related content and is published by the United States National Library of Medicine (NLM) and the National Institutes of Health (NIH). A basic search for "wellness" retrieved over 7 million results (as of 2025)! And the majority of it is peer-reviewed which makes it a good source for evidence-based information.

Alternatively, a public library may have access to academic information through some of their database content. [Google Scholar](#) could be yet another option, but not everything in the search results is peer-reviewed, so use caution if this is the direction you take.

Once you find a good source of information related to the activity you are considering, you might be ready to engage in the activity or you might find that it leads you to dig deeper into the research. Either way is okay. If you are digging deeper, you might try different databases or look into the references found in your first source.

This activity can be done individually, but if done in a class setting, it can also be a group project. For a group project, it is recommended that every member of the team be responsible for providing at least one peer-reviewed resource.



Figure 12.1: Librarians can help you find evidence-based information. (Photo by [Kampus Production from Pexels.](#))

- Computer with access to Internet to:
 - Brainstorm wellness activity ideas
 - Search scholarly databases
 - Gather supporting resources

Once you have found some information supporting a wellness activity, it is time to act. Using the same structure as the other modules, it is recommended that you spend 1 hour learning and trying the activity as an introduction. If this is being done as part of a group project or class, adjust the time to fit the class schedule. For example, you might consider limiting each group to 10 minutes for introduction of the topic and class participation in a mini-activity session.

Since this is a choose your own adventure, the possibilities for alternatives and variations are nearly infinite. In case you are experiencing a bit of a block in trying to pick an activity, here are some possibilities to consider:

- Pet therapy
- Drum circle
- Using a sauna
- Aromatherapy
- Tactile stimulation (e.g., kinetic sand)
- Zen gardening
- Athletic competition
- Volunteering
- Trying a new hobby like crocheting

? Weekly Recommendations/Homework 12.1

Incorporate the activity into your week for at least 1 additional hour.

Also, consider sharing your activity with the authors of this text. Feel free to contact them with the activity you chose! Maybe it could become a new chapter in the future!

Reflection Questions

1. Describe any changes you noticed in the following areas when doing your activity this week:
 - Emotional
 - Environmental
 - Intellectual
 - Occupational
 - Physical
 - Social

- Spiritual
2. What benefits did you feel with your activity?
 3. What, if any, barriers did you experience with your activity?
 4. Do you have any additional thoughts and/or future plans for for your activity?
 5. What are your current stressors and do you have a wellness goal for this week?

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13: Reassessment

Reassessment

Congratulations! You have made it through a number of activities that focused on giving you opportunities to explore different approaches to research-based wellness. These activities were intended to help you learn about self-care strategies and hopefully more about yourself as well.

One of the most common research study designs is often called pre-test/post-test. In this design, a researcher gives an assessment to a person, provides them with an intervention, and then retests to see if there was any significant change. At the beginning of this text, you did a number of assessments meant to give you a baseline or starting point for how well you were doing around self-care, stress management, and wellness. The various wellness activities over the past weeks were the intervention. And now it is time to retest! After all, what would a wellness course that is grounded in evidence-based research be without doing our own individualized assessments?

Activity

This week, you will repeat the assessments that you completed for the first activity. As a reminder, there were five assessments that you took during the first activity and will take again this week:

1. Princeton U Matter
2. Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale
3. Hassles & Uplifts
4. Symptoms of Stress
5. Resting Heart Rate

It should be noted at this point that you should **NOT** go back and look at your initial results until **AFTER** you have taken these assessments again for the second time. Doing so could introduce bias into your responses which could lead to inaccurate results and conclusions. The goal is to assess as you are in your present state.

Materials Suggested

- Device with access to Internet (and possibly a printer) to access the assessments to be completed.
- Writing utensil and paper or note app to document results
- Optional: SmartWatch for tracking heart rate

Note: You can either download and print the assessments or take them digitally. Regardless, you need to document your responses for each assessment (if appropriate) for your reflection

Directions

Please take the time needed to carefully fill out the five assessments and record your results using the Assessment Summary. As a reminder, it is also recommended that you **NOT** look at the results of your initial assessments until after you have retaken all of your assessments. The chart is also available as a PDF download: [Assessment Summary](#)

Assessment Summary

A table depicting each assessment, a place for scores and notes and comments.

Tool	Your Score	Notes or Comments
Princeton U Matter: Emotional		
Princeton U Matter: Environmental		
Princeton U Matter: Intellectual		
Princeton U Matter: Occupational		
Princeton U Matter: Physical		

Princeton U Matter: Social		
Princeton U Matter: Spiritual		
Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale		
Hassle & Uplift: Hassle		
Hassle & Uplift: Uplift		
Symptoms of Stress		
Resting Heart Rate		

Princeton U Matter

The *Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment* prompts the user to consider their current state in 7 different dimensions including: emotional, environmental, intellectual, occupational, physical, social, and spiritual.

Take the assessment using one of the links below:

- [Electronic access to Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment](#) (recommended for ease of use of results)
- [Print version of Princeton U Matter Wellness Self-Assessment](#)

Social Readjustment Rating Scale OR Students' Stress Rating Scale

The Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS) or Students' Stress Rating Scale (SSRS) measure the impact of various life events on your well-being.

Pick one of the following to complete:

- [Electronic access to Social Readjustment Rating Scale](#) (recommended for ease of use of results)
- [Print version of Social Readjustment Rating Scale](#) OR [Print version of Students' Stress Rating Scale](#) (no electronic version available)

Hassles & Uplifts

The Hassles and Uplifts Scales (HUS) was constructed as a tool to focus on relatively minor events that happen in everyday life.

Take the assessment using the link below:

[Print version of Hassles and Uplifts Scale](#)

Note: Please read the full directions for completing the assessment to ensure you are completing the assessment accurately. After assigning a score of 0-3 for each item, add the score up for all Hassles, and then add up the score for all Uplifts.

Symptoms of Stress Table

The Symptoms of Stress Table can be used to identify what stress is doing to the body.

Take the assessment (found on page 2) using the link below.

[Symptoms of Stress Table](#)

To quantify this table, add up the scores as follows for each answer: Almost all day, every day (6 pts.); Once or twice daily (5 pts.); Every night or day (4 pts.); 2-3 times per week (3 pts.); Once a week (2 pts.); Once a month (1 pt.); Never (0 pts.). Record your total score in the assessment summary table.

Resting Heart Rate

Your heart rate can be used as one indicator of health and provides a quantitative piece of data to track.



On the Wrist

Figure 13.1: Find your pulse on your wrist. Take your heart rate for 60 seconds. (Photo by BruceBlaus from Wikimedia Commons)

Take your heart rate. If you are not familiar with taking your heart rate or could use a refresher, here are some step-by-step instructions from the [Mayo Clinic](#).

Assessment Summary

If you have not already done so, please record your assessment scores and any interesting observations or notes you had from taking these assessments again: see the [Assessment Summary](#).

Now is the time for you to look back at the results from your initial Assessment Summary. Where possible, consider both your overall score as well as individual item or question comparisons to note the smaller changes that you had.

- What stayed the same between your initial assessments and today's assessments?
- What was different between your initial assessments and today's assessments?

? Reflection 13.1

Perhaps you have seen some of the improvements you were hoping for, such as a decrease in a physical symptom or better emotional regulation. If so, that is great! However, it is also possible that the scores indicated that you have MORE stress now than when you started. Remember that there are a lot of "unseen" factors that can play a role in assessment and lower scores may not always indicate that things are "worse". For example, if you are taking these assessments around finals week as a college student, some of your scores might be higher, showing the stressors that come with the end of the semester. For other scores, they may be lower due to the removal of certain life stressors or fears. The numbers alone do not tell the whole picture.

It is important to continue to reflect on the why behind the numbers. Use the questions below to reflect on the changes that you noticed between the initial and current assessment.

1. What implications or "take aways" do you notice after comparing the assessment summaries?
 - Why did things stay the same or why did they change?
 - What life circumstances have changed since you took the initial assessment? For the good or for the worse?
 - What changes are more subtle and nuanced reflecting a consistent perspective on your wellness?
2. What changes do you notice in your own understanding of yourself and how you analyze the results?
 - Are you more connected with what you are feeling and the stress-related triggers you experience?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [Reassessment Reflection - Chapter 13](#)

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14: Closing and Reflection

*"What we call the beginning is often the end
And to make an end is to make a beginning.
The end is where we start from."*

T. S. Eliot from [Little Gidding](#)

In starting this journey of exploring your wellness, you ended the routine you were doing before and made a new beginning. Now you are at a different end - the end of the structure this text provided - but you have the opportunity to be at a new beginning where you can continue with habits and wellness activities that are intentional and responsive to your needs. As noted at the outset of this text, the real impact is in **what you will do with the information you learned** about yourself. The goal of this closing section is to help you process what you have learned and think about new goals you can set going forward.

Near the beginning of this text, you did an in-depth evaluation of your wellness. You were prompted to consider three questions coming from the [Model for Improvement](#):

1. What am I trying to accomplish?
2. How will I know that a change is an improvement?
3. What changes can I make that will result in improvement?

Do these questions sound familiar? Hopefully! Because they are the key questions of this text. They provide a system and structure that can be used for improvement, not only personally related to wellness, but in many professional and vocational settings as well. They can help with both big and small decisions and are a framework for improvement.

In Weekly Recommendation/Homework 2.1 of this text, you were asked to reflect on the three questions and come up with 3-5 specific goals that you could work towards to improve your wellness. Additionally, most of the wellness activities had a reflection question that also asked for a wellness goal. Go back and find your responses to both the initial reflection prompt and the weekly goals and consider the following questions in light of your earlier responses.

- How did you progress in meeting the overall goals you set?
- Have the changes you made been an improvement based on your initial goals/reflection?
- Why do you think you were able to meet that goal? Or why didn't you meet that goal?
- Consider some of your weekly goals from the reflections. Were you successful in meeting some of these weekly goals?
- How did those weekly goals help you (or did not help you) meet the larger goals?

Lastly, we would gently encourage you to set some new goals that reflect your learning and development.

- What are your future plans for wellness?
-

Closing

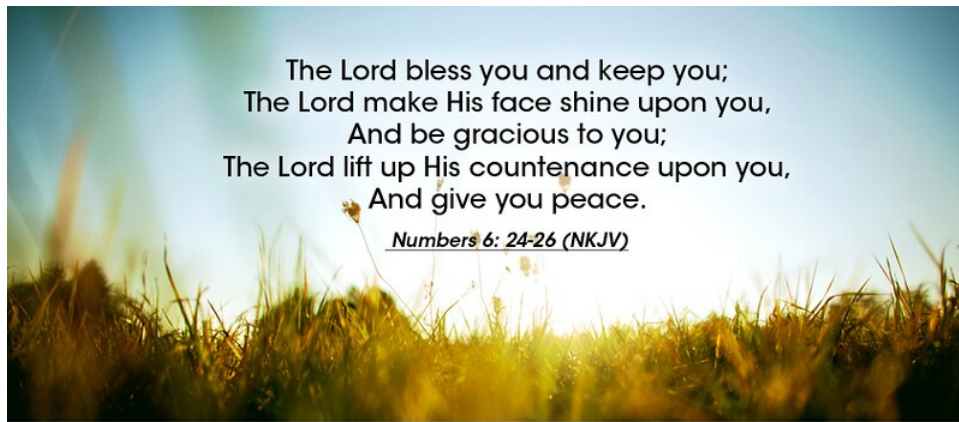
One of the objectives of this text is to help you assess and identify your own wellness needs. At the end of each week's activity, we encouraged you to reflect on the information you learned and notice changes that you were experiencing. How do you feel? Do you feel more in touch with your body, mind, and spirit? Do you feel more equipped to be responsive to your wellness needs? In case it was not clear:

Your reflection matters.

A space for reflection can provide the opportunity to routinely check in and continue moving forward with a growth mindset that both recognizes how far you have already come and what path you want to continue going forward with in the future. Including a time in your daily routine - even 5 minutes - to check-in with your mind, body, and spirit is key to living a life that is balanced.

Wellness is a journey! Exploring wellness activities can and should be a life-long pursuit. Our hope is that this text has given you tools to live this balanced life and that not only will you integrate some of these activities into your own life, but that you will share what you have learned with others. Nothing in this text has to be a secret! By sharing and teaching others, it will help to instill the concepts that you have learned deeper into your core and provide a richer, fuller life experience.

May the Lord bless you on your journey.



To encourage others to pray for peace of Jerusalem, LIKE and SHARE this verse
LIKE ME AT: [facebook.com/drmikeevans](https://www.facebook.com/drmikeevans). FOLLOW ME AT: @DrMichaelDEvans

Figure 14.1: The Lord bless you and keep you; the Lord make His face shine upon you, and be gracious to you; the Lord lift up His countenance upon you, and give you his peace. (Image by Dr. Michael D. Evans from Facebook.)

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About the Authors

Dr. Tina Decker is a nurse educator with a passion for promoting wellness. With a background in nursing higher education and clinical experience in women's health, Dr. Decker has seen firsthand the toll that stress and burnout take on nurses, nursing students, and other helping professions. Inspired by a darkly humorous meme that asked, "Why did the nursing student cross the road? To get hit by a car," she felt a deep conviction: the culture of burnout should not be the norm. From that moment, she committed to shifting the narrative.

This commitment led her to create a *Wellness for Helping Professions* course—initially designed for nursing students and eventually expanded to include a broader range of healthcare professionals. The course grew to incorporate insights from guest speakers, collaborative educators, and a wide array of wellness strategies, all of which laid the foundation for the development of this text.

Dr. Decker holds a Doctorate of Nursing Practice from Governor's State University, is a registered nurse and a certified nurse educator. She lives with her husband and three children and enjoys reading and taking walks for her own wellness practice.

Ms. Emily Pacholski is a nurse educator with a specialty in maternal-child health and a deep passion for promoting the mental health and well-being of nursing students. With 18 years of experience as a bedside nurse in labor and delivery, postpartum, and neonatal care, Emily has witnessed the emotional and physical toll that nursing can take and is committed to preparing future nurses to thrive in their careers. Her dedication to student wellness stems from her belief that resilience and self-care are not luxuries, but essential professional skills for success in today's fast-paced healthcare environment. Her passion for this work inspired her to collaborate on this *Wellness for Helping Professions* text and empower each student to reach their full potential while maintaining personal balance and well-being.

Emily holds a Master of Science in Nursing Education. She lives with her husband and three children and enjoys reading, jogging, and spending time gardening. She also prioritizes her own wellness by making time for rest—and never underestimates the power of a good nap.

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